

DECODED EXPLAINED

2nd August, 2026

India-China trade through Shipki La resumes after six years

Press Trust of India
SHIMLA

The cross-border trade between India and China through Shipki La, known as the ancient Silk Route joining India with Tibet, resumed on Saturday after a gap of six years.

Himachal Pradesh Revenue and Horticulture Minister Jagat Singh Negi on Saturday flagged off 16 traders after presenting traditional Khataks (ceremonial scarves) along with their horses towards Shipki village in Tibet. The Minister said that the exchange of various goods would take place via a barter system.

He also inaugurated a modern trade mart (Chhuppan Trade Mart) constructed in the Shipki La area in the border Gram Panchayat of Namgya in Himachal's Kinnaur district at a cost of ₹1.70 crore to facilitate border trade, a statement said.

Vast scope of trade

Responding to the Traders' Association's request to expand the scope of import-export goods, the Minister stated that the proposal would be placed before Himachal Pradesh Chief Minister Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu so that it could be conveyed to the Chinese government through the Ministry of External Affairs, following the necessary procedures.

Mr. Negi said that the resumption of trade via the Shipki La route would provide new strength to the economy of the border areas and would increase employment and self-employment opportunities for local youth, besides boosting commercial activities in the region.

Five finger policy

Mao Zedong, the founding father of the People's Republic of China, formulated the "Five Finger Policy."

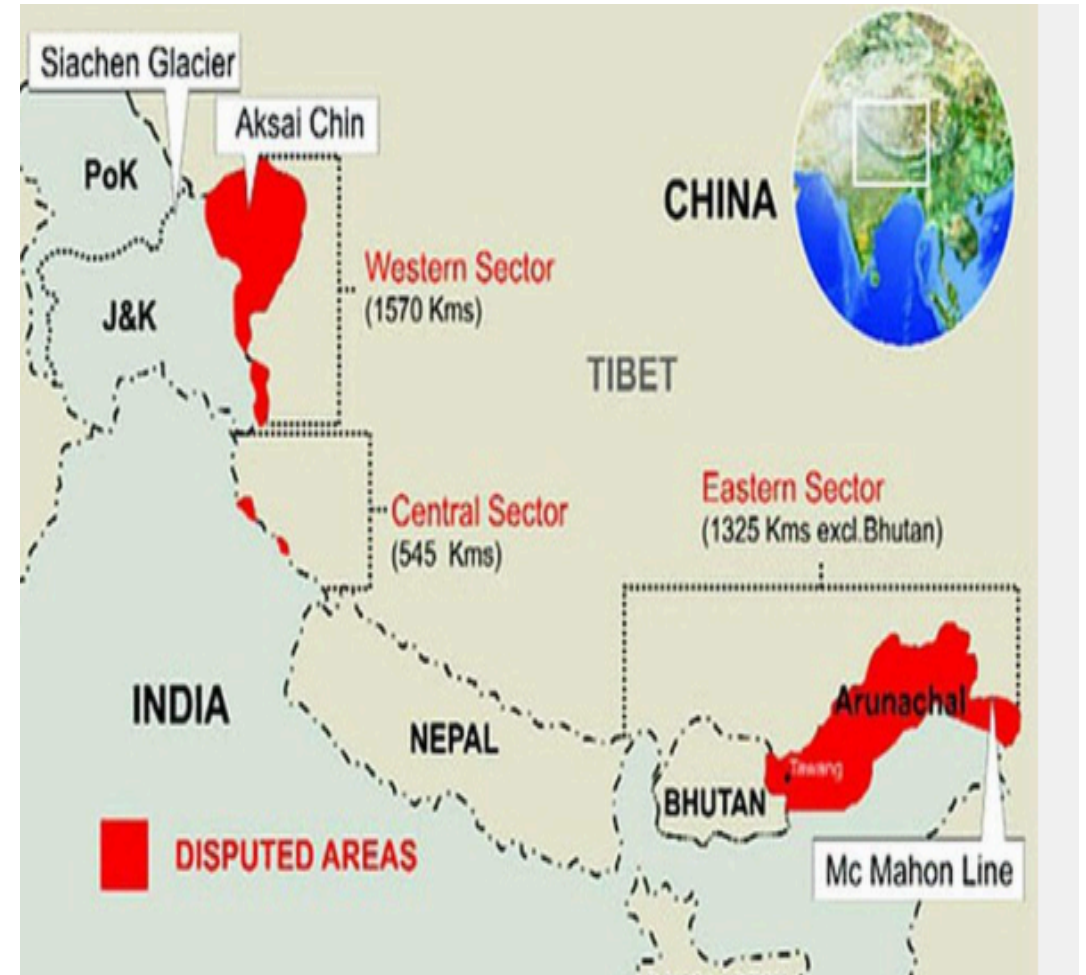
He asserted that **Tibet** was the right palm of China's hand, while **Ladakh, Nepal, Sikkim, Bhutan, and Arunachal Pradesh** (then known as the North-East Frontier Agency) were the five fingers.



Salami slicing is a military and geopolitical strategy used by China to achieve incremental territorial expansion through a series of small, covert actions that avoid triggering a major war. Key elements include **gradual land grabs**, **gray-zone tactics**, and shifting the **Line of Actual Control (LAC)**

McMahon Line

- **Sector:** Eastern Sector.
- **Origin:** Proposed by British administrator Henry McMahon at the **1914 Simla Convention**.
- **Geography:** Separates **Arunachal Pradesh** (India) from Tibet (China).
- **Status:** India recognizes it as the legal international boundary, but **China rejects it** and claims Arunachal Pradesh



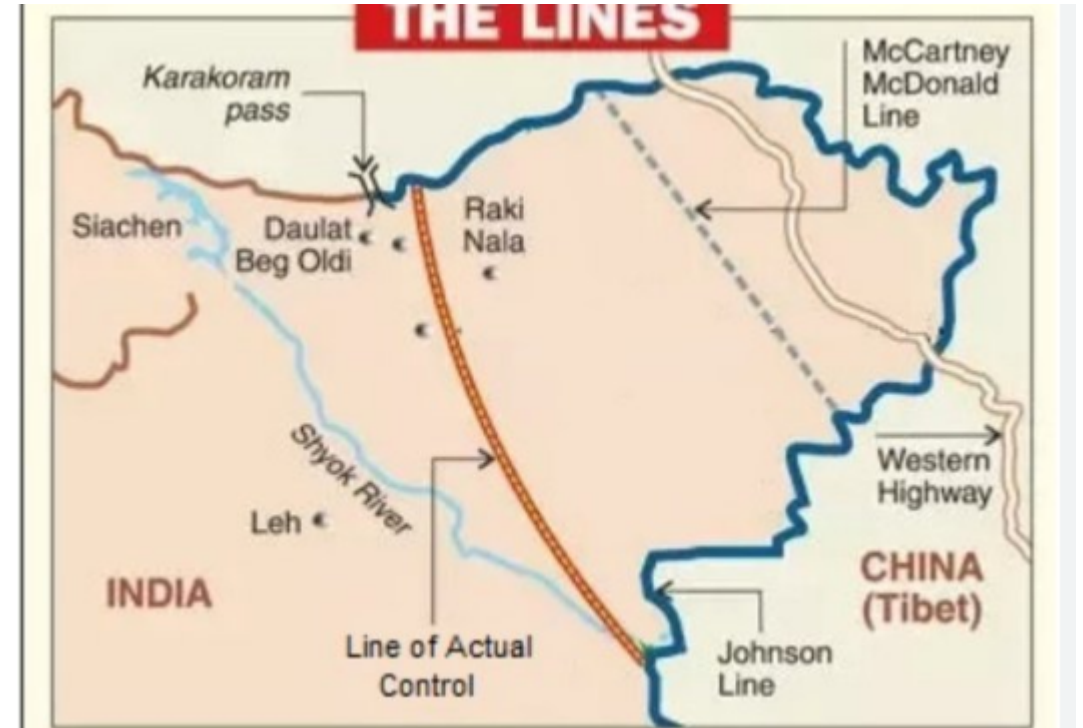
Johnson Line

- **Sector:** Western Sector.
- **Origin:** Proposed in **1865** by William Johnson, a civil servant with the Survey of India.
- **Geography:** Places the entire **Aksai Chin** region inside Jammu and Kashmir (now Ladakh).
- **Status:** India's official territorial claim is historically based on this line. **China completely rejects it**



Macartney-MacDonald Line

- **Sector:** Western Sector.
- **Origin:** Proposed to China by the British Indian Government via Sir Claude MacDonald in **1899**.
- **Geography:** Places **Aksai Chin** under **Chinese sovereignty**.
- **Status:** China historically favored this baseline. However, the proposal was never formally signed or ratified by either government.



Line of Actual Control (LAC)

- **Sector:** Entire border (split into Western, Middle, and Eastern sectors).
- **Origin:** Emerged as the **informal cease-fire line** after the 1962 Sino-Indian War.
- **Geography:** Separates Indian-controlled territories from Chinese-controlled territories.
- **Status:** Functions as the **effective military border** today. It remains un-demarcated, leading to differing perceptions of the line and localized border standoffs.



Major Frictional points

Shipki La – Himachal Pradesh

Lipulekha - Uttarakhand

Nathu La - Sikkim



A call for disaster drills for Indians



RONY MATTHEW KOLL

WHEREVER WE live in India, we now face some form of extreme weather. The danger may be a heat wave, cyclone, cloudburst, flash flood or landslide. The hazards differ, but no part of the country can assume it is safe. Yet most of us have never taken part in a disaster drill.

Every summer, people collapse. Every monsoon, children and adults are swept away. During the recent Assam floods, 13-year-old Iridip Parika entered the floodwaters to save his puppy. He saved the animal, but lost his life in the current. Many of these deaths unfold within minutes, before trained help can arrive. Survival depends on a few immediate decisions.

In a recent assessment, we found that hot days have increased by about five to ten degrees per decade since the 1960s, while extreme rain events causing floods over India tripled. Meanwhile, India has improved its ability to forecast heat waves, cyclones and heavy rain. Alerts now reach millions through television, mobile phones and social media. However, a warning only tells us that danger is approaching. It does not teach us what to do. That knowledge has to be learnt and practised before the emergency.

A World Health Organization regional report cites 36,362 drowning deaths in India in 2021. Just 15 centimetres of fast-moving water can knock an adult down, while about 30 cm can carry away many cubs. Yet people routinely walk, ride or drive into floodwater without knowing its depth, speed or what lies beneath.

India needs a national culture of disaster drills. Every school, college, government office and workplace should conduct two mandatory seasonal drills each year, one before the heatwave season and another before the monsoon.

A heat drill should simulate a student or worker developing severe weakness, dizziness or confusion. Participants should know who calls for medical help, where rapid cooling will begin and who checks on those at greater risk. Every institution should identify a shaded or cooled room, maintain drinking water and know when outdoor work, sports and assemblies must stop.

A monsoon drill should be equally practical. Students and staff should walk the evacuation route to higher ground, practise head counts and use an alternate route in case the main exit is flooded. They should learn never to enter or drive through moving water, and to stay away from submerged drains and electrical wires. Children should be taught to throw a rope or flotation aid from a safe position and call trained rescuers, instead of jumping into the water. Survival swimming and basic water-rescue skills should become part of education in flood-prone districts.

Disaster management must become a practical part of education from the primary level. Children should learn local hazards, warning colours, safe routes, signs of heat illness and basic first aid. Older students can learn emergency communication, evacuation and community volunteering. These abilities should be demonstrated, not memorised. A child who learns them at school will also carry them home.

India is not starting from zero. The National Disaster Management Authority (NDMA) already provides for school disaster plans, mock drills and village-level drills. Schedules based on local hazards. Yet a six-state survey found that most schools had not held the drills, many lacked evacuation plans and only about a quarter had trained staff and students.

Japan shows what sustained preparedness can achieve. During the 2011 tsunami, around 2,000 schoolchildren in Kamakura reached safety after years of disaster education taught them to move quickly to higher ground. In June 2020, Taiwan tested how multiple agencies would respond to three consecutive days at 40°C. Bangladesh has built a standing network of about 76,000 coastal volunteers trained to carry warnings to communities, organise evacuations, manage shelters and provide first aid.

Every panchayat and urban ward should designate at least one local safety point. It should be accessible to people with disabilities and have water, cooling, first aid, toilets, backup lighting and communication. Its location and routes should be displayed publicly. District disaster management authorities should coordinate drills with schools, health departments, fire services, local governments and trained volunteers. Strong infrastructure, health services and emergency response remain essential.

Half an hour of practice twice a year is a small demand. In an emergency, the decisions made during those first few minutes can determine who reaches safety.

Koll is a climate scientist at the Indian Institute of Tropical Meteorology.

Europe pioneers ‘firefighter donkeys’ to prevent wildfires

Sambavi Parthasarathy

As firefighters in France and Spain continue to tackle raging wildfires that have forced thousands of people to evacuate, communities farther from the frontlines are turning to donkeys.

The Tivissa Donkey Firefighters and El Burrito Feliz, two grassroots initiatives in Spain, are using these equines to reduce the risk of forest fires by letting them merely be

themselves. Because when they are, they feed on dry grass and scrubland, thus curtailing the amount of flammable vegetation, especially in high-risk areas.

While grazing does not replace other traditional wildfire prevention methods like the use of machinery to create firebreaks, early detection, and manually clearing land, the donkey solution has emerged as a cheaper and effective way to slow the speed and reduce the in-

tensity of fires.

Joan Cedo Sans, the founder of Tivissa Donkey Firefighters, which rehabilitates and redesignates donkeys as ‘firefighters’, told *The Hindu* that the initiative is a win-win for everyone involved: the animals, the people, and the environment. He said he preferred donkeys over other grazing animals due to their greater appetite and better sturdiness. Since donkeys weigh more than, say, goats, he also

said they tread harder and thus better break the connected layer of dry foliage that fires often require to spread. The trails left by donkeys also help firefighting teams find paths as they work to contain fires during emergencies.

Founded in 2020 during the COVID-19 pandemic with just three abandoned donkeys, Tivissa today houses a herd of 62. “All the animals came from abandoned and difficult situations. When we res-

cue a donkey, we need two or three months or maybe four to rehabilitate them psychologically and physically, or sometimes for a period as long as 18 months.”

Such initiatives emphasise how important it is to revive traditional methods and co-exist with animals, but they don’t come easy. Mr. Sans said, “It’s so difficult at this moment to have or create more projects like Tivissa Donkey because we have a lot of ad-

ministrative challenges. All the animals have to be identified with a passport and moving them requires a lot of paperwork. It’s easier because we’ve been doing this for more than six years but if somebody wants to start, it’s difficult because of the bureaucratic problems.”

While governments continue to ramp up efforts to contain the fires, Europe can also count on a herd of donkeys chomping away to prevent the next one.

The institutional framework for **Disaster Management (DM)** in India follows a decentralized, **three-tier structural architecture** established under the **Disaster Management Act, 2005**

Tier Level	Governing Body	Chairperson	Executive / Operational Arm
National	NDMA (National Disaster Management Authority)	Prime Minister (Ex-officio)	NEC (National Executive Committee) headed by Union Home Secretary
State	SDMA (State Disaster Management Authority)	Chief Minister (Ex-officio)	SEC (State Executive Committee) headed by State Chief Secretary
District	DDMA (District Disaster Management Authority)	District Magistrate / Collector	District Collector & Local Authorities (PRIs / Municipalities)

GST collections rose 15.4% in July on imports, sales

Press Trust of India

NEW DELHI

Gross Goods and Services Tax (GST) collections grew 15.4% to more than ₹2.11 lakh crore in July on higher mop-up from sales and imports, reflecting sustained domestic consumption. Gross GST collections were ₹1.95 lakh crore in July compared to ₹1.83 lakh crore recorded in the same period last year.

Tax collection from domestic transactions grew 10.1% to more than ₹1.44 lakh crore, while

gross revenues from imports were up 29% to ₹66,511 crore.

GST collection reflects continued economic resilience despite challenges in the external environment, according to M.S. Mani, Deloitte India Partner.

“Steady growth in GST collections each month on domestic consumption indicates that overall domestic consumption is becoming largely insulated from seasonal variations and external headwinds,” Mr. Mani said.

The **Goods and Services Tax (GST)** is a structural, comprehensive, multi-stage, **destination-based indirect tax system** in India. It was implemented on **1st July 2017** via the **101st Constitutional Amendment Act**, subsuming a cascade of central and state indirect taxes like VAT, Central Excise Duty etc.

Constitutional Provisions

- **Article 246A:** Grants simultaneous power to Parliament and State Legislatures to make laws regarding GST.
- **Article 269A:** Entrusts the Government of India with the collection and apportionment of Integrated GST (IGST) for inter-state trade.
- **Article 279A:** Mandates the creation of the **GST Council**, a joint forum of the Center and States

The GST Council Structure & Voting Mechanics

Chairperson: Union Finance Minister.

Members: Union Minister of State for Revenue/Finance and Finance Ministers of all States/UTs.

Voting Split: The Central Government holds **1/3rd voting power**; all State Governments combined hold **2/3rd voting power**.

Decision Threshold: Every decision requires a strict **3/4th (75%) majority** of weighted votes present, making consensus essential

Cotton output to dip in 2025-2026 season

M. Soundariya Preetha

COIMBATORE

Production of cotton during the current marketing season that commenced on October 1, 2025 is estimated to be seven lakh bales less than the previous year.

The Committee on Cotton Production and Consumption that met in Mumbai on July 29 expected the production this season to be 290.24 lakh bales of 170 kg each, while the production in 2024-2025 was 297.24 lakh bales.

Consumption of cotton by large-scale and MSME textile mills, which are the main consumers of cotton in the country, is likely to be 320 lakh bales while it was just about 306 lakh bales last season.



Cotton consumption is likely at 320 lakh bales this season.

While cotton exports so far are six lakh bales less than the 2024-2025 season, imports have increased by almost 15 lakh bales.

“We expect the cotton season to end in September with nearly 60 lakh bales of import,” said chairman of the Southern India Mills’ Association Durai Palanisamy.

Climatic & Physical Requirements for cotton cultivation

- **Temperature:** Warm and sunny climate ranging between **21°C to 30°C**
 - **Frost-free Period:** Requires a minimum of **210 frost-free days**, as hard frost harms the plant
 - **Rainfall:** Needs moderate rainfall of **50–100 cm**
 - **Soil:** Thrives in moisture-retentive **Black Cotton (Regur) soil** in the peninsular region, deep alluvial soils in the northern river plains, and mixed red-black soils in the south
 - **Vulnerability:** Extremely sensitive to **waterlogging**; fields must have proper drainage
- ❖ According to data from the **Economic Survey 2025-26** and the latest crop estimates for the 2026 season, **Maharashtra** ranks as the leading cotton-producing state in India, contributing roughly **24.80%** of the country's total output. It is followed closely by **Gujarat** and **Telangana**

Thank You

